

Services, Path Infotech.

**Makes freshers industry ready.** Statistics say only 20 to 30 per cent engineers are employable after procuring their engineering degree and certification courses make them 'employable' in the true sense. "Today's engineering curriculum is designed to fulfill requirements of past but technology across globe is moving at a rapid pace. Due to lack of proper R&D environment and practical facilities in colleges, students get very little understanding and exposure to practical implementation of engineering concepts. Certifications help freshers acquire relevant skill sets keeping them at par with current and future trends of the industry," says S.S. Bhowmick, director, Nex-G Exuberant Solutions, which offers training courses in mobile communication technologies. "Certifications are like value addition for students. They help freshers gain job-specific knowledge that will ultimately lead to employability," adds Varada Murthy, CEO, People First HR Consultants.

**Proof of your competency.** Earlier the competence of professionals was verified by word of mouth, but in today's global and technologically advanced society, new ways of recognising competence have emerged, one of which is certification. "A recognised certification programme helps employers judge with a neutral platform by means of a certification," says Dilip Mendens, director, *Asra* Transatlantic. Certification serves as a proof of competency for engineers. "Certification builds a certain level of confidence amongst employers. The structured learning that happens during preparation for certifications, helps to form a base for the engineer on which the employer can build the required level of capability in a shorter time," says J.A. Bhavsar, group head (IT), ITM Business School.

**Adds credibility to working professionals.** In today's employment market, employers require tangible evidence of credibility of an engineer's ability. "The ground reality is that certifications remain the key differentiator when a company is deciding on promotions or finding tal-

## What's Hot in Certification?

1. As the telecom business grows into a multi-trillion dollar industry, there is a need for professionals certified in telecom, wireless, mobile communication software and mobile applications.
2. Certifications in infrastructure management services, security, unified communications and storage, which include aspects of virtualisation and architecture, have a huge demand.
3. With natural and manmade disasters increasing, risk management and packaged application support are emerging as high demand skillsets.
4. With automation and intelligent electronic products growing, certifications in embedded systems are also in high demand.
5. Some other courses that prepare you for the technology needs of varied industries are supply chain management, project management, total quality management and six-sigma, quality compliance related courses, etc.

ent for latest innovations. It remains the tiebreaker for promotions. If I am looking for talent within my organisation for new projects I instantly search for people having certifications of the skillsets required for that project," says Mehra.

"A well designed training programme can help any trainee to excel in existing jobs and also helps them to explore new opportunities. For example, in mobile application development, a Symbian programmer can enhance knowledge in upcoming mobile platforms, like LiMo, iPhone, BlackBerry and Android. Similarly, a 2G/GSM engineer can learn new wireless network technologies, like 3G-UMTS, WiMAX and LTE," elaborates Bhowmick.

**Helps beat recession pangs.** Certification also might just be the reason that saves your job during gloomy times. "Recession or no recession, the last ones a company wants to lose is people with good hands-on experience and knowledge. Certifications give that," says Kumar. Adding on, Mehra says: "Even during the current recession, companies were looking or holding onto people-skills with multifaceted features. For instance, they wanted employees who were team players, had good communication skills, hands on experience and project management skills. Certifications could help employees fill some of these gaps they probably had."

## The selection criteria

Before deciding on the type of a certification programme, individuals are required to first evaluate what they wish

to learn, where they want their career to progress, and simultaneously analyse how well the programme will prepare them for the future. Thereafter, they can decide on the degree or level of training required. Providing some tips, Bhowmick says: "While deciding on a certification programme, an individual should analyse the depth of training content, its relevance in the industry, training delivery methodologies, lab facility, ratio of theory to practical sessions, evaluation practices, placement opportunities and post-training technical support."

Verification of the credentials of the institute is crucial, assert Kumar and Murthy. "Evaluate the credentials of the institute by taking a few demo classes, surprise visits to the centre and contacting alumnus of the institute. Also pay the fee in instalments; don't get attracted by discounts," advises Kumar.

Adding on, Murthy says: "Ask for references, verify affiliations and claims like the following where the institute claims its certificate programme qualifying candidates for a particular type of job in a particular country, or for all international jobs." Checking on the value-add it provides is also essential. "Consult experienced professionals of the same domain about the market value of the course before going in for it," says Kumar.

As the industry brushes aside the recession gloom, ready to once again cruise the boom tide, make sure you have the certifications and skill sets to glide along. Happy sailing! ■